

Stayin' Alive

Let's find out what the Dotcoms that survived did right!

Dotcoms. Venture Capitalists. Content. Eyeballs. 'Click-throughs'. Portals. Vortals. Brick-and-mortar. Clicks-and-mortar. B2C. B2B. C2C. E-commerce. E-tailing. Multi-crore valuations. IPO. NASDAQ. Stock options. Dotcom bust. Layoffs. Streamlining. Business models. Revenue models.

We've sure come a long way since the early days of the Dotcom frenzy with hype and hoardings dotting city skylines. The Dotcom bubble was mostly a creation of perceived low barriers to entry as the Internet promised infinite possibilities. There was a phase when everybody believed that brands and core competence were old concepts and that anybody could become an Internet media publisher and make money as advertisers move to the Net.

'Eyeballs' was the magic word and in a bid to attract them, many Dotcoms spent their valuable venture capital money on advertising heavily in traditional and new media. Thus began the meltdown.

In the battle to 'make it big' and get a grip on a business that was entirely new, many perished. However, some emerged from the wild roller coaster ride, stronger and ready to take on the future, online.

This list includes portals and Web sites from areas as diverse as travel to online shopping to personal finance. But all of them have one thing in common: they're survivors who started out as 'Dotcoms', but built profitable businesses.

Their formula for success: good old business sense and the flexibility to take advantage of emerging opportunities and adapt to changing scenarios. Here are the secrets that helped these Dotcoms not only survive the downslide but also thrive.

1. Show me the money!

What's common between survivors such as *Traveljini*, *Naukri* and *C2W*? Nothing, except the fact that they started out with a business concept and a revenue model from the very outset.

Naukri followed a 'pay-to-list' model for job listings at prices that ranged from Rs 475 to Rs 6 lakh. *Apnaloan's* revenues came from various avenues: fees from banks for sourcing credit card applications, licensing their technology, and prospecting insurance. At *Traveljini*, online traffic is translated into sales. Leisure holidays are the main revenue generators followed by travel related services and then the usual advertising and listing fees.

C2W's business model was first based on creating content for companies and

